

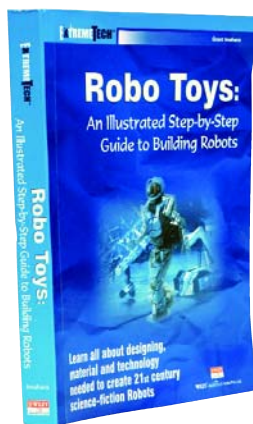
Build Your Own Pet Robot

GRANT IMAHARA IS no amateur. He works on animatronics and model-making for George Lucas's Industrial Lights and Machines and was one of the geeks behind R2-D2 in Star Wars.

Imahara sticks to the basics and practicalities of serving his passion—designing and building robots fit for the battles of BattleBots. And in this, he leaves nothing out. Right from picking up the paper, designing the robot components, selecting tools, to assembling drives and control systems, to what not.

A better part of the 500-page book reads like a starter course on workshop technologies. If you have been nurturing that fantasy of having a wire-bristling pet someday, go get a copy of this book. Don't worry about skipping a page or two and landing up clueless. You can trust the detailed troubleshooting sections.

The book is also a must-read for those who love tinkering with homegrown mechanics. The richly-



illustrated pages will guide you through metalworking, fasteners, housing and installing motors, mountings, transmissions, wheels and tracks, power system, and even pneumatics for gizmos.

The book doesn't shy away from doing the mathematics wherever required, sprinkling essential formulae at several places. However, the Appendix provides all the specs in American standards.

Grant gives us a lowdown on IFI system programming without actually intimidating with gory details, in the Appendix. Another gem is a wealth of

online resources provided in the Appendix.

In Grant's own words—"This is an expensive sport, and you should have an idea of what you are getting yourself into." His introductory robot costs around \$4,000.

Rahul Singh

Robo Toys: An Illustrated Step-by-Step Guide To Building Robots

Publisher **Wiley Publishing, Inc.**

Author **Grant Imahara** Price **Rs 349**

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BOOKS

One For the Bot Killers



YOU PLAY JACK Carver—stranded on an island with a pistol, a bad temper, and a taste for bot gut. Before each mission, you have to endure a singular long load. This is one of the primary reasons that there's a seamless transition as you move from coast to coast or the indoors to the outdoors.

Whilst playing the game, there aren't any loading hassles in between, but the territory comes with an irritating encumbrance in terms of the save mechanism. The game will only pause occasionally during checkpoints, which is where a save point is created. You cannot save your progress in the game whenever you feel like, and in a game such as *FC*—offering more than 20 hours of reasonably tough game play—this can be tiring.

The AI in *FC* is something else. Bots show their inhospitality rather vehemently. Once they see you, fighters will summon fellow coded gun slaves, or follow you for a considerable distance. All-in-all, Crytek has come up with a gem of a game.

SKOAR!

Far Cry

Publisher **Crytek**

Developer **Ubisoft**

Web site www.farcry-thegame.com

GAMES

Shocking and Awful!

BACK TO BAGHDAD picks up from where its predecessor left off. Surprisingly, *BTB* is still set in 1991.

BTB, however, disappoints hugely on all fronts. America may have won the war, but Pivotal Games is fighting a losing battle against bad gameplay. To its credit, the missions are varied.

You start off by rushing to the rescue of a downed chopper à la *Black Hawk Down*, then blowing a communications station to Kingdom Come, getting caught by a bunch of ferocious Iraqis, escaping (and blowing

up a chemical weapons plant, if you please), and finally neutralising 'super-guns'. There are 10 agony-filled missions.

The default view is from a third-person perspective, where moving around is relatively easy, but accurate firing is impossible. The first-person mode just doesn't have the FPS feel to it.

There isn't a single hotkey for any weapon in the game. It might be excused on the grounds of trying to make combat more realistic. If any joy was to be wrung out of the game at all, it's killed by the poor 'inventory management'.

SKOAR!



Desert Storm II—Back To Baghdad

Publisher **SCI Games**

Developer **Pivotal Games**

Web site www.conflict.com

List Courtesy Crossword Mumbai